

IN CONTEXT

Fairies and folk wisdom

Cunning men and women frequently invoked, and had conversations with, an array of spirits that were generally thought of as fairies. In effect, fairies were a magic practitioner's familiar (spirit helper)—similar in some ways to the animal familiars that they also often used (see pp.186–187). For example, a cunning man might consult his fairy spirit guide to discover where someone's lost object was hidden. Other beings that featured in popular magic included elves and fantastical creatures such as the unicorn (pictured, right); so-called unicorn horns—in reality often narwhal tusks—were considered especially potent for magic and folk healing practices.

The Unicorn in Captivity is a Dutch tapestry, dated 1495–1505.



used for countering bad witches was a witch bottle containing a variety of materials, each said to have specific effects; for example, a person might put their own urine into the bottle along with pins, with the aim of making a witch feel pain when passing water. Sticking needles into a poppet (doll) that represented someone on whom harm was wished was another tool of sympathetic magic. Poppets were traditionally used for both good and bad (see pp.182–183) across Europe, in the American Salem witch trials, and in certain Voodoo rituals.

Sympathetic magic linked to the wider, ever more popular concept of universal sympathy, in which humans were believed to have close correspondences with the universe around them. In the Renaissance, this was promoted by many scholars of natural philosophy and Hermeticism (see pp.134–135).

Transferring power

The idea of transference was crucial to cunning folk—for example, placing a live chicken against plague buboes was believed to somehow transfer

the illness to the bird. Similar practices included washing an ill child in water that was then discarded, in the belief that the illness would be transferred into the water, allowing it to be disposed of; and putting a healing potion onto the sword of an injured soldier was thought to transfer the healing benefit to him.

Household charms

People were eager to protect their homes from malevolent spirits. Items such as mummified cats, silver coins, and witch bottles were hidden in walls and chimneys to achieve this. Cats were significant because of their links with witches and reputation for detecting demons. Shoes were another hidden apotropaic item, probably because, molded by their owner, they were thought to contain that owner's spirit; their shape was also suitable for trapping demons. Protective symbols might also be marked around the house, such as on beams and windowsills.

▼ Lucky shoe

This man's left shoe, from around the late 1600s, was found in a wall between a window and chimney of a Cambridge University college. It was probably placed there to protect the college's master.



“When I was a Boy, our Countrey-people ...
were wont to please the Fairies.”

JOHN AUBREY, *REMAINES OF GENTILISME AND JUDAISME*, 1686–1687